Find A Way (Back Home)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53713246.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fluff, Domestic Fluff, POV Catra (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), she misses her girlfriend, Pizza, Surprises, Couch Cuddles, Cuddling & Snuggling, Fluff and Angst, Light Angst, Tooth-Rotting Fluff, Romance, Established Relationship, Long-Distance Relationship, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Sort Of, there's nothing really from the show aside from the characters, I Wrote This Instead of Sleeping, Tags Are Hard

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by Haha_thatsH0t

Summary

It's like missing a limb, Catra decides. A very painful, noticeable limb that has her screaming silently to herself in the bathroom mirror at five in the morning because she couldn't sleep *without* that limb.

She decides she hates it.

OR:

Catra suffers just like I was when I wrote this, but she gets a reunion.

Notes

Happy Valentines, to those who celebrate <3

See the end of the work for more notes

It’s like missing a limb, Catra decides. A very painful, noticeable limb that has her screaming silently to herself in the bathroom mirror at five in the morning because she couldn’t sleep *without* that limb.

She decides she hates it.

After all, it’s not her fault she couldn’t sleep; not her fault that her pillow doesn’t cradle her head right, or that when she lifts her head in a dream-like stupor, no one is there to press gentle kisses to her forehead to lull her back to sleep.

Adora has ruined everything, so she decides to blame it on her.

She lays in her bed, staring at the ceiling and scrutinising the colourful dots her tired eyes tell her are on it. She cards a weak hand through a knot in her hair and doesn’t bother picking her arm up when it collapses above her head. Her other hand traces slow, nonsensical patterns on the exposed skin of her stomach, scratching mindlessly at an itch on her rib.

It’s like going stir-crazy with nowhere to point her pent-up aggressions. No matter how many stupid romance novels she reads, no matter how many runs she goes on, no matter how she shifts her pillows and blankets to try and fail to replicate the comfort of sleeping in Adora’s arms, nothing works. She’s halfway to tearing her hair out.

She misses her girlfriend. She misses her like her lost sleep and her hugs and her dumb little jokes. Because, as much as she misses these things — misses *her* — Adora lives two fucking hours away, and trains don’t run close enough to where she lives. And — she muses on this fact with bitter, sleep-deprived spite — she doesn’t have a car to drive to her, and it’s too far to bike.

And it’s not even like they don’t talk! They talk daily, even in short snippets and dumb little videos sent back and forth. They call often enough. But Adora’s picked up more shifts lately, and her

sports keep her otherwise occupied. And her friends. Adora spends a fair bit of time with them.

So they don't talk quite as much as they used to. And that's fine!

But the point is, Catra grouses, rolling onto her side irritably, *that it's so fucking lonely.*

But she's not going to bother Adora over something that small. She's not going to ask her to make room in her already packed schedule for something so minor, especially since peaceful days come by so rarely for Adora lately. She won't ask for Adora's arms to open because Catra knows how eagerly she will, and she knows Adora doesn't have time to spare.

So she won't mention it. She'll grin and bear it, maybe slipping a sly 'I miss you' into the conversation when it's quiet enough. She'll hope that Adora gets the hint on her own so Catra doesn't drown in the guilt of it. She'll hope.

She drags herself out of bed and into the kitchen, pours herself a large cup of overly sweetened black coffee, and ignores the part of her that whispers that it's how Adora likes it, not her, and settles in to watch the sunrise from her kitchen window. There's a growing, gnawing, hunger-like pang in her stomach. She ignores it — because she knows what she's doing — brushes it away with the blurry vision and spinning head into the same convenient little excuse. *She's just tired.*
Catra hasn't seen her in weeks, but it's hardly worth mentioning. Besides, she can persuade herself that the occasional Facetime is enough — might even convince herself that it's *Adora* she's cuddled into, instead of one of the many oversized pillows that relocated from Adora's flat at some point. Maybe if she keeps her eyes closed and the lights dark, she can pretend she isn't the only one in her apartment.

She takes a sip of her coffee, and it's far too sweet. She doesn't know how Adora drinks it like this. She takes another absent sip

anyway as she glances at the clock. It's seven now, somehow, so Adora's probably going on a run.

She places the mug down and meanders back into her bedroom to fetch her phone, ignoring the tangled sheets. One of the pillows is on the floor. She doesn't bother to pick it up and snatches her phone from her bedside table.

Faithfully and forever on schedule, Adora's good morning text is on her lock screen next to her usual emoticon heart. Catra's heart, forever a bastard, aches a little more at that, even as she shoots a quick good morning back. Adora won't respond for another half-hour because Catra's rarely up this early on purpose.

That done, she finds herself hovering, bored, aimless. She can't go back to sleep without feeling the leeching cold of the other half of her bed, and she doesn't have plans for the day. So she wanders back into the kitchen and finishes her coffee, wondering if she should bother cooking breakfast.

With a put-upon sigh, she opens the fridge and half-heartedly snags a few slices of bacon. She could cook them, maybe eat them raw, but her chest feels hollow in the specific way it does when she's sleep-deprived, and she decides she doesn't have the patience to wait for it to cook.

She holds it bunched in her fist and bites into it like that, uncaring of the vaguely slimy texture as it worms its way down her throat. It's satisfying enough, and even though it smells indescribably like her fridge, it's just enough to satiate the real hunger pangs. She knows that Adora would cook for her, just out of spite, if she saw her do that.

She stands there in the kitchen for a few more minutes, irritated by the sensation of crumbs on her feet but not bothered enough to do more than brush each foot against her legs in turn. It's light outside now, and the weather seems nice enough despite the lingering chill from early morning. Should she grab a jacket? The sun looks warm.

She grabs an apple on her way out of the door, absently sliding on a pair of sandals and resolutely ignoring that she hasn't brushed her hair or teeth or even changed out of her pyjamas. Catra sinks her teeth into the reddish, slightly bruised apple and figures it's okay to go outside in an old band t-shirt that permanently smells vaguely of sweat and grey cotton shorts.

She climbs down the stairs of the apartment complex lazily, not having a real destination in mind. Then she stops on the last stair and turns back, barely remembering that she left her phone in her room.

Phone acquired and safe in her pocket, Catra continues on her path out of the building, nodding slightly to the exhausted single mother who lives three doors down, trying her best to reign in her errant children with an apologetic grimace in her direction. Catra keeps moving but waves to one of the older kids who ding-dong-ditched her once upon a time.

She briefly pauses before she heads in the general direction of the market she saw the other day. If nothing else, she figures it'll give her something to do. And hopefully, it might put all lonely thoughts of Adora far out of her head.

She walks for a while, just enjoying the morning. The sun is barely too bright — kind of annoying, really — dappling shiny spots onto the ground between the arching, thick branches of the trees lining the path. The breeze blows blessedly cold if nothing else, and she hadn't realised how warm it had been in her apartment before then. It soothes the beginnings of a headache she didn't know was there.

Her feet feel lighter than usual, and so do her legs, just like they always do if she hasn't slept. They spin in entertaining circles in time with her head, but she doesn't feel unsteady. She giggles breathlessly just for the sake of it and because she can smell the uncooked bacon on her breath and the rank odour from her unbrushed teeth, mixing with the scent of all of the fried food trucks lining the entrance to the park.

The market is decently busy but not packed when she finally arrives. Stalls upon stalls line the edges of the park that Catra walks through sometimes, people milling between wood carvings and paintings and the occasional fresh fruit and veg stand.

Catra walks through the crowd, eyeing the wares and creations as she eats her apple. Nothing catches her eye, but being out of the house and away from her thoughts is nice. The sun helps her stay awake, too, which is always helpful.

She *could* always go back to her apartment for a nap. She could *try,* at least, because her bed seems to hate her lately. Too cold, too little pressure, ~~not enough Adora.~~ Catra thinks for a moment, daydreaming. Adora's arms are always stupidly warm, but they're never irritating. Her stomach and chest are soft but stabilising, cradling in a way that removes the tension from Catra's body like nothing else — not hot baths, not professional massages, not anything that Catra has ever found — ever does.

(Because baths are just you soaking in grimy water, and why would you let a stranger rub oil all over your partially naked body and stand at your back? They might be what society has deemed relaxing, but that's just ridiculous.)

But. Catra looks around the market again and sighs. It turns out that getting out isn't distracting her after all. Resolutely, she turns on her heel and plods back to her apartment because maybe something on TV will distract her *properly.* Maybe another crappy rom-com, or perhaps an action movie just to spice things up.

Back on her couch, teeth clean, and down to a sports bra and underwear — because her landlord also likes spicing things up, particularly by refusing to fix the broken cooling on a now-hot day — Catra reclines and scrolls through the channels, waiting for something to catch her eye. Her streaming subscription expired the other day, and she hasn't gotten around to renewing it, so she's stuck between a game show and some random reality TV show; neither is tempting.

She's just debating the merits of calling Adora — busy or not, there's *nothing* on TV — when there's a series of knocks on the door.

Maybe it's her three-doors-down neighbour's kid again, trying his luck with another ding-dong-ditch. Perhaps it's a misdirected parcel or a delivery that she'll have to turn away. She doesn't think she's ordered anything recently.

As she drags herself off the couch, half-nakedness be damned and growing slightly irritated at the impatient knocking, she supposes that she could always act like it *is* her delivery, just to see what her neighbours like to order. If she's lucky, maybe they paid online.

If she's lucky-*er,* it'll be Adora at the door, responding to her telepathic pleas.

Catra laughs shortly and half-heartedly runs a hand through her hair to tame it if only to give the impression of being more put together than she really is. She still hasn't brushed it, and she really should. There's a knot by the back of her head, and it's tugging now that she notices it.

She opens the door, and the first thing she sees is the pizza box. The second thing she sees is the brown-haired teenage boy in a rumpled-looking uniform. And despite knowing how slim of a chance it was, her heart falls. It isn't Adora. But the scent of the pizza is tempting, and she decides that even if the original customer didn't pay for it online, she might as well take advantage of it. She's hungry enough, in any case.

"Uhh," the teen says eloquently, eyes fixated firmly on the skirtings of her doorframe. The poor kid is bright red. It's unreasonably funny. "Meatlovers pizza for, um, Catra?"

"Yeah," Catra replies, right before she registers what the kid just said. "Um-"

"Great." She's cut off, and it's less funny that the kid won't meet her gaze because she *didn't order pizza,* and *dammit* she wants *answers!* "Your payment was, um, processed fine online, so-" he shoves the box at her and turns quickly, tipping his uniform cap at her as an afterthought- "I'll be on my way. Have a good day!"

And he disappears down the hallway.

Catra blinks after him, mouth still agape as she tries to process that entire interaction. Because what the fuck was that? Then she turns her stubborn attention to the pizza box in her arms, warm cardboard drawing a thin layer of sweat to her forearms. She stares at it as if the fatty, sweet-smelling meat, cheese, and bread (her favourite, and who ordered this?) hidden beneath has the answers she wants.

She opens the lid, stepping back inside in a daze. The door clicks shut behind her, but she doesn't care enough to register it. It's thick, stuffed crust, and when she hesitantly lifts the outside edge of one of the pieces, it reveals hot tomato paste. Who the fuck ordered this? In her name? To her apartment? Her favourite pizza?

Her phone buzzes from its spot on the couch, the vibrations halfway muted because of the cushions that sandwich either side of it. She places the box on the coffee table and brings her phone into the open.

Adora's calling.

Catra answers the phone with half-numb fingertips and sharply exhales as she brings it to her ear. "Hey," she greets, surprised and pleased at the randomness despite the confusion still warring in her chest. "Adora."

There's a crackling noise on the other end like she's opening a chip packet or rattling keys into a lock. "Hey, Catra," Adora replies, and Catra can hear her smile when she says it. "How are you holding up?"

"Terrible," she wants to say. *"I miss you."* She huffs out an amused breath instead and turns to look out the window. "Like always," she settles on. "Why'd you phrase it like that?"

Adora laughs, soft and warm, and it buzzes through Catra's chest like a drunken bumblebee. "Because you answered my good morning text at seven — and you only do that when you haven't slept. I just saw it now." There's something gently chastising in the words, but it doesn't make Catra bristle like it would with anyone else. "Have you taken a nap today? Or eaten something proper?"

Catra eyes the pizza and remembers the bacon and apple from earlier. "I ate. And, uh, I have pizza in front of me."

There's blatant disbelief in her voice, and Adora snorts. "And you're surprised?"

Now it's Catra's turn to snort. "Yeah, 'cause I *wouldn't* be surprised when a pizza I didn't order shows up at my door." She shakes her head slowly, even though Adora can't see it, and smiles affectionately, her tone entirely sarcastic and fond. "I know it's a regular occurrence for you, idiot, but you don't remember half the things you order. You could probably throw your own surprise party."

Adora laughs too, and it settles in Catra's stomach and aggravates a bit of the panging ache that had dulled since this morning. God, she misses her. "Probably, but that's not my point, dumbass!" Her voice shakes with humour, and Catra sits back on the couch and closes her eyes to soak it in. "Did you read the receipt?"

Catra opens her eyes and blinks, caught off-kilter. "The receipt?" Did she even get one? She looks around, finds it on the floor beside the couch, and leans over to grab it. "What about it?" There's *nothing* special about it that she can see.

"Maybe your secret admirer left you a message? Or some clues, at least." Her tone is vaguely sarcastic — like Adora's teasing her,

Catra realises — as if she knows more than Catra does and finds it funny.

“Adora…” Catra questions mock-cautiously. “What are you hiding?”

Adora laughs, and then there’s a flurry of enthusiastic knocks on the door. Not from the phone. Catra snaps to attention, and the phone falls slightly from her ear. “Is someone at your door?” Adora giggles, clearly exhilarated. “You should really get that.”

And then the line goes dead.

Catra spends a grand total of two seconds switching between staring at her phone and the door before the situation catches up with her, and she practically trips over herself to get to the entrance. The knob is warm under her palm, like Adora’s arms, like her smile, and it takes a moment to actually open.

Then she’s looking up, and there she is, her phone still hovering by her ear, a cheeky grin splitting her face. She’s gorgeous, blonde, tall, and so undeniably Adora that Catra doesn’t pause in her momentum before she’s crashing into her opened arms, name on her lips.

“Adora!” she cheers, trying to tunnel into the warm junction between Adora’s neck and shoulder like it’ll save her from ever leaving, “You’re here!”

The phone is returned quickly to Adora’s hoodie pocket, and then Catra is lifted higher and higher into her girlfriend’s arms, raised off the ground, cradled and so safe and surrounded by Adora that her heart feels like it’ll explode.

Adora’s smiling just as much as Catra is, and when Catra leans down to meet it in a flurry of kisses, her lips are soft, and her mouth is warm, and she can feel the curve of Adora’s smile against her own.

They pull apart tentatively, grinning like idiots, forehead to forehead and a tangle of limbs.

“I’m here,” Adora whispers — as if she can’t quite believe it herself.

“You’re here,” Catra repeats just as quietly. She presses another kiss to the corner of Adora’s mouth and grins when she gets a proper kiss back. Deep and affectionate and *Adora’s home.* “Let’s go inside?”

Adora nods, adjusts her hold on Catra instead of putting her down, and steps carefully through the doorway to ensure Catra doesn’t hit her head. “Couch?”

“Yeah.” She leans bodily onto Adora’s shoulder, curling her arms around her neck and breathing deeply. Something gently unwinds itself in her chest, stomach, arms, legs and lungs, and soon it’s relaxing the pressure in her eyelids too — threatening to close them for far longer than the blink she meant to take. She reflects, absurdly drowsy for barely a minute-long hug, that this is the limb she was missing, the absence that kept her from being able to sleep.

It’s incredible to have it back.

Adora sits them both on the couch but keeps Catra curled on top of her like she knows she loves, leaning against the armrest to spread out her legs and carefully shuffling to lie down. “Scooch,” she urges when Catra’s leg prevents her from moving low enough to place her head on the armrest. “I know you’re tired, Catra, but please, I had a long drive here. I want a nap, too.”

She’s probably pouting, Catra suspects, and cracks open a heavy eye to confirm her guess. And indeed, Adora’s pouting. Catra smiles sleepily and presses a hand into the couch just enough to boost herself up and settle a chaste kiss on Adora’s cheek. Purely out of spite, however, she moves her leg up and over Adora’s hips so she’s straddling her and pinning Adora’s legs to the couch.

She lies back down on Adora’s chest, listening to the stuttering heartbeat, and makes a show out of wiggling around to get

comfortable. She hides her grin in the side of Adora's hoodie as her girlfriend groans and calls her unfair.

Soon, though, Catra gives up on being mean. Because Adora's *here,* and while having her leg like that is pretty comfortable, Adora's been straining her neck to keep her eyes on Catra, and that just won't do. So she slides off of Adora and into the narrow gap between Adora and the back of the couch, keeping an arm flung over Adora's ribcage to keep her from getting any bright ideas — like getting up.

She can feel Adora's questioning gaze on the top of her head, and Catra huffs, "Lay down properly, idiot, before you hurt yourself."

Adora chuckles quietly at that but obediently adjusts herself to lie more comfortably with her head against the armrest. "I don't think I could hurt myself lying like that, but thank you anyway, Catra." She kisses her forehead and snakes an arm under Catra's side and around her back to rest on her hip.

Catra smiles, a small one, and tucks herself a bit impossibly closer to Adora's side before shifting herself to lay back on Adora. "You'd find a way."

Adora hums. "I would."

They fall into comfortable, sleepy silence, soaking in each other's presence and the faint rays of sunlight that escape through Catra's half-closed curtains. The couch is faintly itchy on Catra's arm, and her head rises and falls in time with Adora's slow breaths. If she dies like this, Catra thinks that she will die incredibly happy. Adora's wearing a soft cotton T-shirt, and it's gentle on Catra's cheek.

She turns her head into Adora's chest and places a kiss wherever her face lands, reaching up to cradle the side of Adora's neck. Her eyes stay closed, but she can still feel Adora cup her hand and draw it to her mouth, pressing incredibly soft kisses to her fingertips and down her palm.

They stay like that for a while before Adora hums something and breaks Catra out of her doze. “We should eat the pizza,” she says, petting Catra’s hair lazily. “Before it goes cold.”

Catra hums noncommittally right back, rubbing her face into the middle of Adora’s chest. She figures they could eat it, but in Catra’s mind, that involves getting up; she’s far too comfortable, warm and light and feeling like freshly baked bakery bread to bother even considering that. She says as much but in far fewer words.

Adora nods negligibly, and Catra can only feel her shoulders raise slightly before dropping back into a boneless heap. The conversation peters back out, and the only sound is the languid breathing and a sound that sounds suspiciously like a purr that rumbles in Catra’s throat and chest.

“How do you think the pizza got here?” Catra murmurs a few minutes into their silence. “The receipt didn’t look all that special.”

Adora chuckles quietly, and it bounces Catra’s head against her chest and pulls a smile onto Catra’s face. “I thought you figured it out?” she teases, kissing the crown of Catra’s head. “You’re the one who likes the mystery shows.”

“Shut up,” Catra grumbles half-heartedly, pinching Adora’s side to bully an apologetic yelp from her mouth. “Don’t laugh at me.”

“Catra, love, sweetiepie shnuckums-”

“I will destroy all that you love, you royal *idiot-”*

“-I was the one who got the pizza for you.”

And that gives Catra pause. “You did?” Adora nods, smiling that proud little smile she does when she’s done something ingenious, and Catra can see it now because she’s lifted her head to meet Adora’s gaze head-on. “You-” Catra frowns gently, but her heart flutters in her chest because Adora thinks of her, knows her habits so well that she- “Why?”

The smile widens, and for a moment, Catra just stares in awe at the gorgeous, impossible woman she calls her girlfriend. “Because I love you,” Adora says, like it’s the simplest thing in the world, and Catra is slow for not knowing that immediately. “And you deserve nice things because you’re wonderful-”

Catra cuts her off there because she knows the beginning of a ramble when she sees one. “Adora, I love you, too, but please.”

And Adora grins sheepishly, leaning forward to kiss the tip of Catra’s nose. “I wanted to surprise you,” she admits. “I cleared my schedule for the weekend, and I wanted to distract you until I arrived. It just sort of also ended up functioning as a timer to make sure I got here while the pizza was still hot.” Another kiss and Adora’s hands come up to cradle Catra’s face. The next smile is softer, and the kiss even more so. “I ended up using my usual running time for the drive, but goddamn it, you’re worth it.”

You’re worth it.

And that soothes whatever left of that idiotic ache in her chest and smoothes out the crinkle in her brow.

She’s worth it. And she’s home.

End Notes

...I really miss my girlfriend.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!